Chuan Zhu

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EDUCATION

Fudan University, School of Management — expected 2027
Ph.D. in Business Artificial Intelligence — *Shanghai, China*

- Dissertation focus: Integrating AI in Service Operations.
- Committee: Tianjun Feng.

Northeast Forestry University — 2018
B.S. in Logistics Engineering

INDUSTRY COLLABORATION AND RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Alibaba Group, Customer Operations Department — July 2022 – Present
Research Scientist; Full-time, Onsite, Academic Collaboration — *Hangzhou, China*

- Collaborate on Human-AI hybrid customer service system design.
- Develop algorithms with causal inference to better manage worker supply.
- Design data-driven strategies to optimize customer service operations.
- Provide academic consulting to support Alibaba's operational innovation initiatives.

Environmental Defense Fund Climate Corps & LONGi Green Energy — July 2021 – Oct. 2021
Climate Corps Fellow; Full-time, Onsite, Internship — *Xi'an, China*

- Analyzed supplier-side carbon-management challenges and green supply-chain opportunities.
- Designed supplier survey instruments and benchmarked leading firms' decarbonization practices.
- Developed a green supplier empowerment roadmap for training, renewable-energy adoption, monitoring, and incentives.
- Project link: https://www.longi.com/cn/sustainability/green-supply-chain/.

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Fields: Service operations; platform operations; empirical operations management.
Substantive: AI-enabled service operations; human-AI collaboration; human-in-the-loop systems; GenAI and AI agents in platform operations; workforce management.
Methodological: Field experiments; causal inference; machine learning; LLM.

WORKING PAPERS

[1] Yiwei Wang*, **Chuan Zhu***, Tianjun Feng, Lauren Xiaoyuan Lu, Bingxin Jia. "Agentic AI and Human-in-the-Loop Interventions: Field Experimental Evidence from Alibaba's Customer Service Operations." (Job Market paper, **co-first authorship*), major revision at *Operations Research*.

- **Finalist, 2026 INFORMS Service Science Best Student Paper Competition.**
- Studies how firms should deploy and govern agentic AI in customer service operations when autonomous AI systems interact directly with customers and human workers remain in the loop.
- Uses a randomized field experiment and causal inference with large-scale customer service operational data from Alibaba Taobao's customer service operations.

- Shows that agentic AI reduces average chat duration but may lower customer ratings for AI-eligible chats; human intervention is more effective for technical escalations than emotional escalations, with effectiveness shaped by intervention timing and post-escalation human effort.
- Available at SSRN and arXiv.

[2] **Chuan Zhu**, Tom Fangyun Tan, Tianjun Feng. "Managing Front-office and Back-office Effort Allocation: Unpacking the Effects of Workload on Service Performance." Working paper.

- Examines how workload shapes online service agents' allocation between customer-facing interaction and back-office problem solving in live-chat customer service operations at a large Chinese e-commerce platform.
- Uses large-scale operational data analysis, a control-function approach with instrumental variables, mediation analysis, and textual analysis using LDA and LLM-based measures.
- Shows that service performance depends on maintaining an intermediate balance between visible customer communication and substantive problem-solving work.

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

- "Agentic AI and Human-in-the-Loop Interventions: Field Experimental Evidence from Alibaba's Customer Service Operations." POMS Annual Meeting, 2026.
- "Managing Front-office and Back-office Effort Allocation: Unpacking the Effects of Workload on Service Performance." POMS-HK, 2026.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Teaching Assistant

- Operations Management, MBA, Spring 2022.
- Data-Driven Market Analysis, Master's, Fall 2021.
- Microeconomics, Undergraduate, Spring 2019.
- Theories and Practices of Entrepreneurship, Undergraduate, Spring 2019.

HONORS, FELLOWSHIPS, AND AWARDS

Climate Corps Fellow, Environmental Defense Fund 2021
Outstanding Academic Scholarship, School of Management, Fudan University 2019

PROGRAMMING AND RESEARCH SKILLS

GenAI / LLM: Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG); Agentic AI; LLM Fine-Tuning; data annotation and evaluation.
Programming: Python; R; Stata; SQL.
Software: MATLAB; LaTeX.

REFERENCES

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